

E. Raji (Vanrawat) Tribe (Smallest — Primitive)

The Raji tribe, historically called "Kings of the Jungle," is the smallest tribal community in Uttarakhand and is classified as a Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group (PVTG). They inhabit the remote forests of Pithoragarh and Champawat districts, living in huts called Rautuda. Their family system is patriarchal and clan-exogamous (marriages are avoided within the same clan or gotra). Bride price is prevalent, where payment flows from the groom's family to the bride's. Elopement is a commonly accepted form of marriage, and child marriage was historically prevalent to secure alliances within the small population.

Pre-marriage rituals include Sangjangi (Mongjangi), a ceremonial meeting of two families to discuss and agree upon the union, and Pintha (Pinda Sanskar), a distinct ritual performed before the wedding to formally bless the couple.

8.3 COMPREHENSIVE TRIBAL COMPARISON TABLE

Feature	Tharu	Jaunsari	Bhotiya	Boksa (Buksa)	Raji (Vanrawat)
Population Rank	Largest	2nd Largest	Largest in High Himalayas	Terai region	Smallest (PVTG)
Habitat	Terai/Bhabar (US Nagar)	Jaunsar-Bawar (Dehradun)	Pithoragarh, Chamoli, Uttarkashi	US Nagar, Nainital	Remote Pithoragarh forests
Origin/Lineage	Thar Desert (Rajputs) or Kirat	Indo-Aryan (Pandava descent)	Mongolian race (Kirat-descendant Khas Rajputs)	Panwar Rajput descent	Agneyavanshi Kol-Kirat
Family System	Matriarchal/Matrilineal	Patriarchal	Patriarchal but Egalitarian	Patrilineal; women hold high status	Patriarchal; Clan-exogamous
Marriage Customs	Badla-Vivah → Three Kathi; divorce (Urari)	Fraternal Polyandry (Bahupati)	Rang-Bang (Youth House); Tatst & Damola marriages	Monogamy & Polygamy (now mostly monogamy)	Bride price; elopement; child marriage
Religion & Deities	Hindu; Jagmathiya Devi	Hindu; Mahasu Devta (Hanol)	Hindu (Jad = Buddhist); Bhumyal, Nanda Devi	Hindu; Chaumunda Devi (Kashipur)	Hindu; Baghnath
Folk Dance	Lahchaari; Khichdi (Holi)	Harul (Ramtula compulsory); Budiyaat	Dhurang & Dhuring; Pauna (war dance)	Traditional folk songs	Ringadans (circular)
Economy	Agriculture; rice wine Jaad	Agriculture; political committee Khumri	Transhumance; historic Tibet trade	Agriculture; Panchayat head = Takhat	Woodcraft; Silent Barter Exchange
Dialect	Blend of Pahari, Awadhi, Nepali	Jaunsari (Indo-Aryan)	Romba (Tibeto-Burman)	Rachbhainsi, Bhavari, Kumaiya	Munda

8.4 DEMOGRAPHIC DATA: SCHEDULED TRIBES

8.7 URBANIZATION & INDUSTRIALIZATION IN UTTARAKHAND

Urbanization Trends & Data

The urban population of Uttarakhand (Census 2011) stands at 30.5 lakh, representing 30.23% of the total. The urban growth rate between 2001 and 2011 was 4.0% annually, significantly higher than the national average of 2.8%. Dehradun is the most urbanized district at 55.52%, while Bageshwar is the least urbanized at 3.44%. Haridwar has the highest population density at 801 persons per square kilometre, and Uttarkashi the lowest at 41. Haridwar's floating population, normally around 2.3 lakh, spikes to over 30 lakh during festivals such as the Kumbh.

The Demographic Divide

A stark demographic divide separates the plains from the hills. On the plains, Haridwar has the highest density (801/sq km), Udham Singh Nagar records the highest decadal growth at 33.45%, and Dehradun is the most urbanized (55.52%). In contrast, Pauri Garhwal shows negative decadal growth of -1.41%, Almora has similarly declined at -1.28%, and Bageshwar remains the least urbanized at 3.44%.

Industrialization Dynamics

The State Industrial Development Corporation of Uttarakhand (SIDCUL), established in 2002, manages seven major Integrated Industrial Estates (IIEs). IIE Haridwar hosts the maximum number of industries, including BHEL, Hero, and ITC. Rudrapur and Pantnagar in Udham Singh Nagar serve as the auto and manufacturing hub. MSME units jumped from 59,798 in 2021-22 to 79,394 in 2024-25, employing 4,56,605 people and contributing approximately 13% to GSDP. The startup ecosystem has grown from zero in 2017 to 1,750 in 2024-25, supported by a Rs 200 crore Venture Capital Fund. The Global Investors Summit yielded MoUs worth Rs 3.56 lakh crore and 4.6 lakh employment opportunities.

Societal Issues from Urbanization & Industrialization

Urbanization and industrialization have generated several societal challenges. Youth migration (Palaayan) to the plains and outside the state has created a "Money Order Economy." Ghost villages — settlements with zero population — numbered 1,048 in Census 2011 and rose to 1,768 by 2018 (RDMC data), with 734 new ghost villages appearing between 2011 and 2018. The migration rate averaged 138 per day from 2008 to 2018, increasing to 193 per day between 2018 and 2022, with 3.3 lakh people leaving villages during that period.

The feminization of agriculture has left women managing both households and unviable farming, with approximately 68% of women still engaged in agriculture earning 45% less than their plains counterparts. Urban areas face infrastructure collapse including traffic congestion, drainage failures, urban flooding, and legacy waste accumulation. Ecological degradation from unregulated construction, deforestation, and inadequate sewage polluting rivers remains a concern, compounded by the geographical concentration of population and industry in the narrow Terai/Bhabar belt.

Government Steps for Urbanization Issues

Government initiatives include the Smart Cities Mission (developing Dehradun and Haridwar), AMRUT 2.0 for expanding water and sewerage networks, the proposed Doon Metro for Dehradun traffic management, tunnel and cavity parking starting in Tehri for space-constrained hill towns, Land Pooling Regulations 2025 for planned urban expansion, a Mega Industrial Policy with special tax exemptions for industries in hilly regions, and the Parvatmala Pariyojana (Ropeways) to distribute tourist and economic load to new circuits.

8.8 MIGRATION (PALAAYAN) — THE DEFINING SOCIAL CRISIS